Intelligence Cycle

Quick briefing

Follow the five stages of the intelligence cycle to turn collected information into a decision-support assessment and revise it as needs or evidence change.

Know the facts

Planning and direction · Define the decision need, set intelligence requirements and prioritize what information is needed.

Collection · Gather information relevant to the requirements from appropriate sources.

Processing and exploitation · Organize, translate or otherwise prepare collected material for review.

Analysis and production · Interpret and synthesize usable information, account for uncertainty and produce findings relevant to the decision.

Dissemination and integration · Deliver the assessment through authorized channels to relevant decision-makers and incorporate it into their planning.

Continuous cycle · Changed requirements or new evidence can prompt more collection, analysis or an updated assessment.

Understand the reasoning

Putting reports in a common format makes them comparable. Analysis establishes whether differences reflect real change, inconsistent definitions or incomplete coverage.

An assessment should separate observations from conclusions and tell the decision-maker which gaps could change the recommendation.

Philippine Army classroom exercise

In a fictional Philippine Army disaster-response tabletop, a school and a municipal office provide different totals for displaced households. The school counts current overnight occupants. The municipal office counts everyone registered that day.

Decision · How should the staff brief the figures for an overnight supply decision?

Worked analysis · Explain the two definitions and use the overnight count for the immediate supply estimate if its time and coverage match the decision. State any likely late arrivals as an uncertainty and arrange an update before the next allocation. The daily total remains useful for a different planning question.

How to practice

1 · Write the specific decision and the time by which the assessment is needed.

2 · List the information required and gather relevant exercise reports.

3 · Align dates, units and definitions so the reports can be compared.

4 · Explain the findings, conflicting evidence and uncertainty. Draft a conclusion tied to the decision.

5 · Deliver the assessment to the authorized audience and update it when new evidence changes the conclusion.

Check yourself

Which stage prepares collected material by translating or sorting it? · Processing and exploitation.

Which stage interprets the prepared information and develops an assessment? · Analysis and production.

Course source

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